

POU33201: Authoritarianism

Week 1: What Is Authoritarianism?

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Welcome

To Authoritarianism

Authoritarianism is lots of things



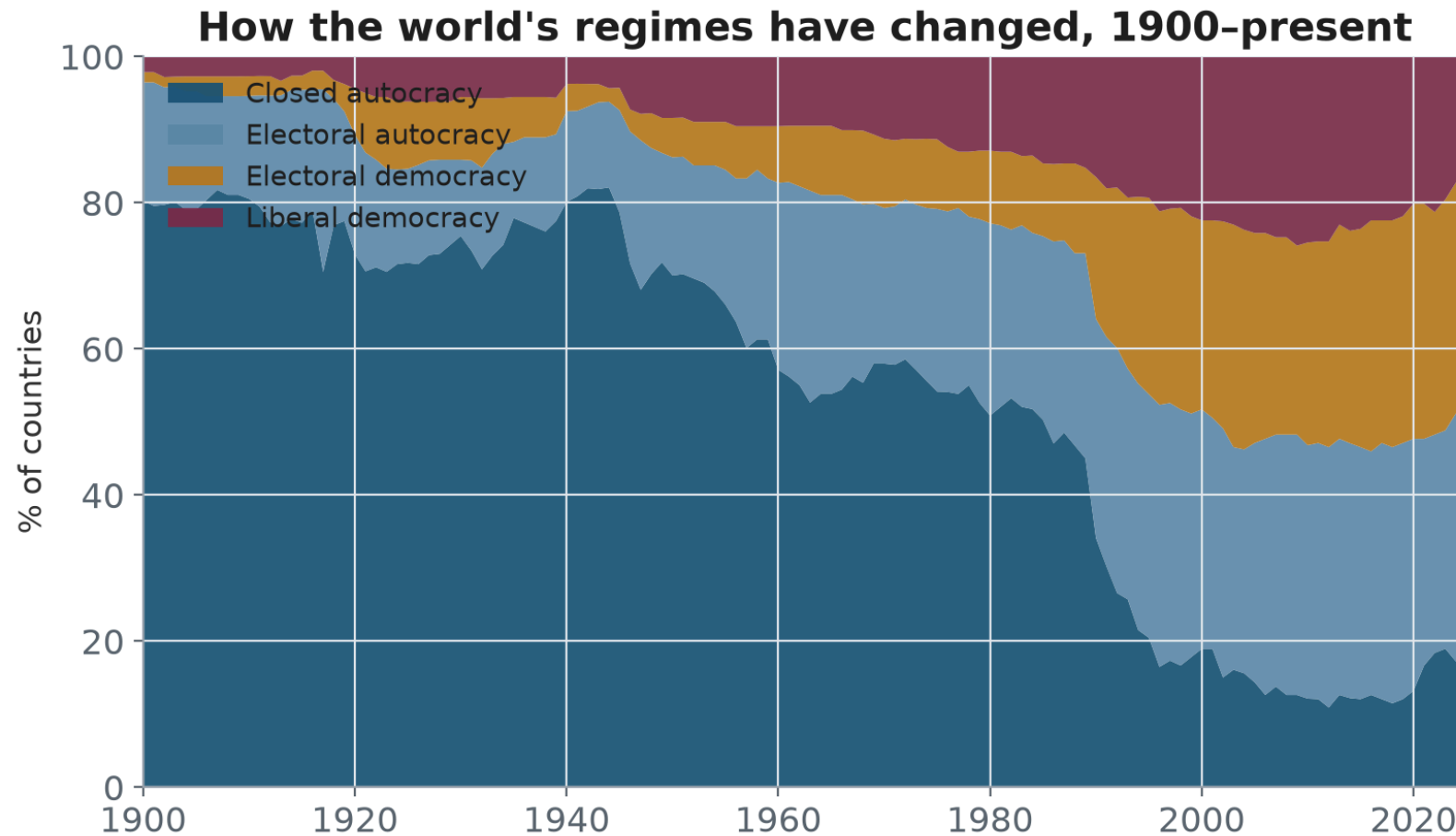
Today

- What this module is, and what I want from you
- What is democracy? What is authoritarianism?
- Most of the world is not free, and it's getting less so (is it?)
- Dictators face at least *two* big problems
- After the break: who I am, who you are, how the module works

Which of these five is a democracy?

Russia. Hungary. Singapore. Mexico (1990s). The United States.

How the world's regimes have changed



Most of the world is not free

74% of the world's population lives under some form of autocracy — and **46%** under an *electoral* autocracy, now the most common regime type.

That share has been **rising** for about fifteen years — the “third wave of autocratization” you’ll meet again in week 12.

So: three of your five guesses were “authoritarian” by most measures.

What people *think* they know about dictators

“It’s all about one evil guy at the top.”

“Dictators rule purely through fear.”

“Elections in dictatorships are meaningless theatre.”

“They’re irrational — or just crazy.”

“They’re always one push from falling over.”

We’ll spend this module complicating each of these!

Goals of this module

- **How** do dictatorships actually *work*? Who really holds power?
- **Why** are so many of them so *durable*?
- What **tools** do autocrats use and what do the tools cost them?
- How do dictatorships **end** and what comes next?

And underneath: get better at political science by taking non-democracies seriously as *political systems*.

Why study dictatorship?

- It's where most people live — and where the century's biggest stories are
- It's a **puzzle**: ruling without consent should be hard. Why isn't it?
- It sharpens our theory of politics *everywhere* — including democracies
- Democracies can **slide** toward it. Hold that thought until week 12

Authoritarianism and political science

This module touches most of political science:

- **Regimes** — what is a democracy, and who decides?
- **Institutions** — parties, parliaments, elections, courts (yes, in dictatorships)
- **Political economy** — rents, patronage, oil, corruption
- **Coercion and information** — repression, propaganda, censorship, surveillance
- **Collective action** — protest, revolution, why nobody saw 1989 coming

Are dictatorships good at anything?

Growth? Order? Getting things done?

So what *is* authoritarianism?

Where's the line — and who gets to draw it?

How people used to sort regimes

One question is (was?) **who rules, and for whom:**

	For the common good	For themselves
One	monarchy	tyranny
Few	aristocracy	oligarchy
Many	“polity” / mixed regime	democracy (the mob)

We threw out the second axis. Not because it’s unimportant, but because nobody can *measure* “rules for the common good” without picking a side.

Democracy vs. non-democracy — where's the line?

What's the *minimum* a regime needs to count as a democracy?

- Free and **fair** elections?
- More than one party that could actually win?
- Rights — speech, press, assembly?
- The losers actually **hand over power**?

Authoritarianism is, in part, a **residual** category: whatever fails the test.

One working definition

*An **authoritarian regime** is one in which rulers acquire and hold power by means other than free and fair multiparty competition — and are not reliably constrained by it.*

Nothing here about how *brutal*, how *popular*, or how *stable* the regime is. Those are things to **explain**, not assume.

Linz brings the definition

*“...political systems with **limited, not responsible, political pluralism**; without elaborate and guiding ideology (but with distinctive **mentalities**); without intensive nor extensive political **mobilization** (except some points in their development); and in which a leader (or occasionally a small group) exercises power within **formally ill-defined limits but actually quite predictable ones**.”*

— Juan Linz, *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes*

Thick or thin?

Two ways to define things – thick and thin:

- **Thin** (Przeworski, Svoboda): fails the election test → dictatorship. Clean, codable, says nothing about *how* it rules.
- **Thick** (Linz): a whole style of rule — limited pluralism, mentality not ideology, demobilised society.

We'll generally use the thin one to *count* and the thick one to *describe*. Both are choices, and the choice has consequences — that's week 2.

Totalitarian, authoritarian — or neither?

Linz's other distinction. According to his definition, **totalitarian** regimes have:

- a single, official, all-explaining **ideology**
- a mass party that **mobilises** everyone, all the time
- no tolerated pluralism — not even in a chess club



Is North Korea totalitarian? Is China? Was the USSR in 1985?

What's the *one thing* keeping your dictator in power?

Think of a country you'd call authoritarian. Fear, money, ideology — or something else?

One core idea of the module

Every autocrat faces **two problems** (Svolik):

- **Power-sharing** — controlling your *allies*, who could replace you
- **Control** — controlling the *masses*, who could rise against you

Almost everything we study — parties, elections, repression, propaganda, coups — is a **tool for managing one of these two problems.**

Every week, the same question

Is this week's tool for the **elites** or for the **masses**?

Weeks	Tool	Mostly for...
3	Ruling coalitions, commitment problems	elites
4	Repression, secret police	masses (and elites)
5	Parties, parliaments, patronage	elites
6	Elections	masses — and elites
8–9	Propaganda, censorship, surveillance	masses
10	Coup-proofing	elites
11–12	Protest, breakdown, backsliding	when the tools fail

Not all dictatorships are alike

We'll spend week 2 on the varieties. A preview:

- **Personalist** — one leader, thin institutions: Russia today
- **Single-party** — the party runs the show: China
- **Military** — the officers rule: Egypt since 2013
- **Monarchy** — hereditary rule: Saudi Arabia
- **Electoral authoritarian** — real elections, but unfair ones: Mexico under PRI (Magaloni!)



Cases we'll keep returning to



Russia · China · the Gulf and the wider Middle East · Latin America · Africa · and Europe's backsliders

Break

Who am I?

- From Minnesota, by way of a lot of time in Russia and the post-Soviet region
- Political scientist working on **Russian politics, authoritarianism, and corruption**
- Quantitative research, public opinion surveys, elites
- Fieldwork **in Russia** — before the war made that a very different question

Where we're going

Wk	Part	Topic
1	Foundations	What is authoritarianism?
2	Foundations	Varieties of autocracy
3	Dilemmas	How autocrats take and hold power
4	Dilemmas	The control problem: repression
5	Strategies	Buying loyalty: parties, parliaments & patronage
6	Strategies	Elections without democracy
7	—	<i>Reading week</i>
8	Strategies	Propaganda & censorship
9	Strategies	Digital authoritarianism
10	Breakdown	Coups & the military
11	Breakdown	Protest, revolution & breakdown
12	Breakdown	Demise, democratization & “autocracy at home?”

How this module works

- **One two-hour lecture** a week, Fridays 14:00–16:00 — with a break
- The arguing happens **in here** — discussion, most weeks
- **Response papers (10%)** — short, before the lecture, two across the term
- **Mid-term essay (30%)** — due Sunday 1 November
- **Exam (60%)** — in person, end of term, the whole module

Everything is on the module webpage and Blackboard.

What we expect of you

- Discussion happens **here**
- Response papers are due **before** the lecture they attach to: Wednesday midnight
- Do the reading! The lecture assumes it and the exam will reward it

The mid-term essay

Due **Sunday 1 November, 23:59**. Set questions, released in due course.

The exam

- **60%**, in-person, end of term, scheduled centrally
- Covers the **whole module**

Generative AI

If you use it, use it to help you **orient yourself** and to improve prose **you wrote**, not to do the thinking or write the prose.

- Each assessment's sheet says exactly what's allowed
- Every written submission needs the School's **Assignment Submission Form** as page 1, GenAI disclosure filled in. No form, no submission
- The exam is in person; nothing to declare

What I want from you

- **Read before class.** The lectures assume this
- Bring the **comparison** — “but in China...”, “but Egypt did the opposite...”
- Be willing to have your priors challenged
- **Read the news.** I’m begging you!!

Where to follow this stuff

- **Everywhere:** *The Financial Times*, *The Economist*
- **Russia:** Meduza (meduza.io/en), *The Moscow Times*, Mark Galeotti's *In Moscow's Shadows* podcast
- **China:** China Media Project, *ChinaFile*

Bring a story. We'll often try to talk about “what happened this week that belongs in this module?”

This week in autocracy

Duma as I say, not as I Duma

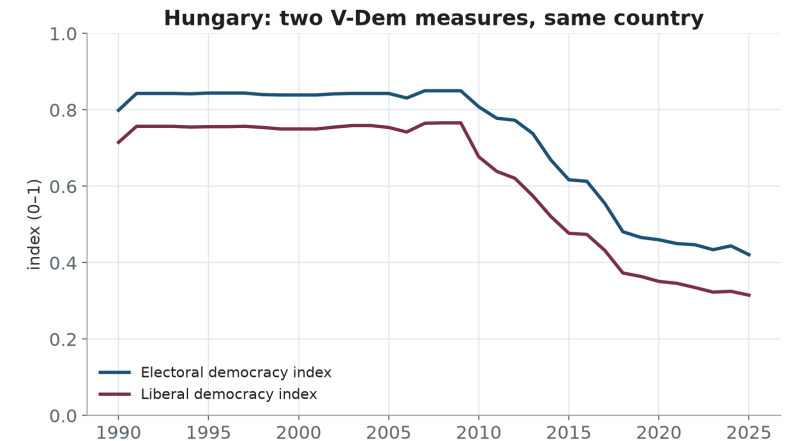
- **Russia is holding elections** right now!
- Elections to the lower house of parliament, the State Duma, being held over the weekend
- Along with many regional and local elections
- Why do authoritarian regimes hold elections?? Isn't Putin's party, United Russia, guaranteed to win?
- I think they are still very informative and interesting

An authoritarian country in the EU?

Three indices score the same country and don't agree.

Was Hungary a democracy under Orban? Depends who you ask!

Week 2: how regimes are measured and categorized



Key readings this week

Required:

- Frantz, *Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know* (2018), pp. 1–13
- Guriev & Treisman, “Informational Autocrats,” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* (2019)

Recommended:

- Linz, *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes* (2000), ch. 1
- Geddes, Wright & Frantz, *How Dictatorships Work* (2018)
- Dahl, *Polyarchy* (1971)
- Linz & Stepan, *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation* (1996), ch. 3
- Friedrich & Brzezinski, *Totalitarian Dictatorship and Autocracy* (1956)

For next week

Week 2 — Varieties of autocracy

Read:

- Frantz, *Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know* (2018), ch. 5
- Levitsky & Way, “Elections Without Democracy: The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism” (2002)
- Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (2012), chs. 1–2 (pp. 1–45)

Think about: pick a country you’d call a dictatorship. What *kind* is it, and could you defend that label against someone who disagreed?

See you next Friday

See you next Friday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou33201-mt2026

Response-paper prompt and readings for next week are on the module page.